

The *hope/expect* colexification: predicates with combined flavours

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The English predicates *hope* and *expect* share several key properties (e.g. future orientation, uncertainty requirement), but differ in their modal flavour (Williamson 2017, 2019, Portner and Rubinstein 2020): *hope* has a strong bouletic flavor while *expect* has a strong doxastic flavor. In some languages, these two concepts are colexified, as in Spanish *esperar*, Ewe (Atlantic-Congo, Ghana) *mɔ kpɔm*, and Bengali (Indo-European, India & Bangladesh) *āśā kara*. In this paper, I show that these predicates differ from previously described variable-flavour predicates (Bogal-Allbritten 2016, Močnik and Abramovitz 2019): in certain contexts, the colexified predicates take both a doxastic and a bouletic flavour. Data in this work comes from elicitations with native speakers, if not indicated otherwise.

Consider the data in (1) and (2). The context is (1) sets up a world which is compatible with a bouletic interpretation of *esperar*, but not with a doxastic interpretation. Expectedly, *esperar* takes the bouletic interpretation (=hope) in the positive polarity in (1-a). Given that the context excludes a strong doxastic interpretation, it is felicitous to use doxastic *expect* with sentential negation in (1-b). The colexified predicates may also be used with negation, and take their doxastic interpretation.

- (1) I'm going camping this weekend. However, the weather forecast calls for rain this weekend. Hence, I think it will rain.
- a. I ✓*hope*/✓*esperar*/✓*mɔ kpɔm*/✓*āśā kara* it will be sunny. (=hope)
- b. I don't ✓*expect*/✓*esperar*/✓*mɔ kpɔm*/✓*āśā kara* it will be sunny. (=expect)

In the example in (2), however, the context is compatible with a doxastic reading but incompatible with the bouletic reading. While English *expect* is felicitous in this context, the polysemous predicates *esperar*, *mɔ kpɔm* and *āśā kara* are not. Crucially, native speakers attribute the doxastic reading to the predicates due to the presence of external evidence (= the fact that Spain has better players than England) but state that the doxastic readings are infelicitous in the added context saying that the speakers wants England to win. This asymmetry between English *expect* and the colexified predicates suggests that the latter

have **both** a doxastic **and** a bouletic flavour in (2), but only a bouletic flavour in (1). With sentential negation, we cannot get a bouletic reading of the colexified predicates with sentential negation. Instead, the colexified predicates can only ever have a doxastic flavour with negation, which is incompatible with the context given in (2).

- (2) Spain and England are competing in an upcoming match. Spain has better players than England. I want England to win.
- a. I ✓*expect*/~~*esperar*~~/~~*ᵐᵒ kpᵒᵐ*~~/~~*ᵕāṣā*~~ kara Spain to win. (intended: =expect)
 - b. I don't ~~*hope*~~/~~*esperar*~~/~~*ᵐᵒ kpᵒᵐ*~~/~~*ᵕāṣā*~~ kara Spain to win. (intended: =hope)

The examples in (3) illustrate that the bouletic component is inactive when the colexified predicates are negated. Compare (3-a) and (3-b), which are taken from the corpus *esTenTen23*. In both examples, *esperar* has a doxastic reading. The complement of (3-a), however, is compatible with the speaker's desires, while the complement of (3-b) is not.

- (3) Corpus *esTenTen23*: token number 484487877, 34533275
- a. No *esper-o* que – en este escenario de esquizofrenia –
NEG ~~*hope*~~/expect-1SG that in this scenarios of schizophrenia
imper-e un poco de cordura.
reign-3SG.SBJV a bit of sanity
'I do not expect that – in this state of schizophrenia – a little sanity will prevail.'
 - b. No *esper-o* que viváis en pobreza.
NEG ~~*hope*~~/expect-1SG that live.2SG.SBJV in poverty
'I don't expect that you live in poverty'

There are at least three theoretical solutions to the observed colexification of *hope* and *expect* in these languages: a) there are two independent, accidentally homophonous predicates in these languages, b) the predicate is underspecified for its modal flavour, or c) the flavour is triggered by lexical material in embedded clause or in the matrix clause. [Williamson \(2019\)](#) treats *esperar* as being underspecified for its modal flavour, which is defined by conversational background. Similarly, [Močnik and Abramovitz \(2019\)](#) argue that the denotation of the Koryak predicate *ivək*, contains a disjunction between an assertive base $\mathcal{S}$ and a doxastic base $\mathcal{B}$. Crucially, both definitions imply that an underspecified predicate can have **either** flavour A **or** flavour b. Under this assumption, the ungrammaticality of (2-a) is unexpected. The third option would be that the modal flavour is induced by external material, as suggested by [Bogal-Allbritten \(2016\)](#) for Navajo *nízin*. In this respect, the bouletic flavour would be the primary flavour, while the *expect* reading could be triggered by the external evidence and/or negation, which matches the observation that speakers translate the predicate as *hope* when no context is given. If we stick with this hypothesis, it still remains puzzling why the bouletic component is inactive with sentential negation in (3).

References

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